policy towards Eastern Europe emerged.

Elsewhere, the new Austrian republic built on the ruins of the Austrian Empire, humiliated and frustrated, shrank to little more than the German-speaking part of the former empire. The Slavic nationalisms of the nineteenth century created an image of the empire that, perhaps, it did not deserve, and it was this image that the triumphant new Eastern European nations were happy to abandon and venture enthusiastically into an unknown future on their own.

A look at the map of post-World War I Eastern Europe reveals a hugely reduced Hungary, an enlarged Romania, and an independent Albania, Bulgaria and Greece. On the shores of the Baltic Sea, Lithuania, Latvia and Estonia won independence from Tsarist Russia. After many years, Poland finally regained its independence. Two new states appear on the map as well: Czechoslovakia and Yugoslavia.

Yugoslavia and Czechoslovakia were a novelty, a product of Wilson's new principle of the self-determination of nations. They were an artificial attempt to create a nation by forming a state. This reflected the way in which many of the oldest European nations had been formed in the past, but with Czechoslovakia and Yugoslavia times had changed and things did not work out as planned – not even after 1990. These two countries (Yugoslavia even more so than Czechoslovakia) did not possess the common ethnicity, history and national myths which were needed to achieve homogenisation or cohesion in a new nation. At the time, Slovaks in Czechoslovakia and Slovenians and Croats in Yugoslavia realised that this was the best they could hope to achieve and that their quest for full national independence could not (yet) be successful. After all, the new states did represent protection against German and Hungarian (and to a lesser degree Italian) nationalism, which had been of major concern to the smaller nations for a very long time. The Czechoslovakian case was also well served by the charismatic figure of President Masaryk, a liberal politician ahead of his time.

Still, Europe in general looked quite promising in the 1920s. Unfortunately, the Communist revolution in Russia brought a new and previously unknown factor into the politics and society of Europe. Marxist academic ideas became flesh where they were least expected, in a country that had not yet become an industrial society. Vulgar Communism, as began